

Key Topics

Gratitude for the Technosphere: An Ethics of Ordinary Technology

Here are the updated notes, with the requested change to the introductory statement and "Patrick" removed from the publisher's name:

Thesis: humanity primarily exists within the "technosphere," rather than solely the ecosphere or biosphere. This fundamental shift necessitates the development of a "**specific ethics of ordinary technology**" [1]. Furthermore, given technology's crucial role in sustaining life and providing comfort, the primary moral sentiment towards it should be **gratitude** [1, 2].

Here are the precise elaborations:

• The Field of Study: Ethics of Ordinary Technology

- The speaker's research domain is the **ethics of technology**, specifically the **ethics of ordinary technology** [1, 3].

- "Ordinary technology" refers to **ubiquitous, everyday items** such as smartphones, computers, shoes, food, and cars, distinguishing it from large-scale technologies like nuclear weapons or satellites [3].

- The speaker is not only an academic but also possesses **three decades of practical experience** advising industrial and technological companies, as well as public administrations, on these matters, providing a "real-world" perspective [3].

- The speaker's major work, *The Ethics of Ordinary Technology*.

• The Concept of the Technosphere

- A central thesis is that "**We live in the technosphere**," not solely the ecosphere or biosphere, and the speaker offers proof for this claim [4].

- **External Manifestations:** Our surroundings are overwhelmingly technological. For instance, in an indoor setting, one sees wooden floors, windows, and artificial light, with very little or no natural elements in the visual field. "**Everything around us, it's not nature, it's technology**" [4].

- **Internal Integration:** Technology is integrated not only around us but within us. This includes clothes, glasses, and for many, including the speaker, medication. Daily sustenance, like a morning meal, is often processed and necessary for life. Even aspects of personal life, such as contraception for romantic life without a baby every year, are highlighted as technological integrations [5].

- **Survival Dependence:** The speaker asserts that most people would **not survive without the technosphere** [5]. The speaker personally attributes their survival on at least two occasions to technological hospitals [2]. Historically, conditions like tuberculosis were "terrible killers" before vaccines, and past mortality rates and life expectancies were "terrifying" [2].

◦ **Moral Imperative: Gratitude:** Given this profound dependence on technology for survival and the "comforts" derived from living in an industrialized country, the speaker argues that the **"first moral feeling for technology must be gratitude"** [2].

• **Global Pervasiveness and Impact**

◦ The influence of ordinary technology extends globally; even in the poorest African countries, **mobile phones are "game-changers"** [6].

◦ They facilitate fluid banking systems, microeconomic opportunities, selling products, and crucial personal and social communication, negating the need for long-distance travel [6].

◦ Mobile phones also provide free access to **"all the literature of the world"** via the internet, addressing issues of paper and ink scarcity. While electricity is needed, it can be sustainably provided through animal traction or bicycle systems [6].

• **Illustration of Technosphere Immersion through Daily Routine**

◦ The deep immersion in the technosphere is evident by tracing a normal day [7]: * Waking up to a **smartphone alarm** that connects to news or music [7]. * Using a **coffee machine and a refrigerator** for breakfast [7]. * Showering with temperature-controlled water and scented soaps [7]. * Commuting via bicycle, car, or train [7]. * Working primarily with **computers or operating factory machinery**; even agricultural workers now operate machines [7]. * Simple technologies like **shoes are also highlighted as crucial**. They are not natural and transform human interaction with the ground, making them "a part of the technological atmosphere" [7, 8].

• **Implications for Philosophy**

◦ Since philosophy aims to understand reality, it must understand **"today's reality,"** which is fundamentally different from the world inhabited by classical philosophers like Plato or Kant [8].

◦ The speaker notes that philosophers like Nietzsche "never saw a computer" and "had no idea what Facebook is" [8]. While past moral philosophy can be useful, it **must be adapted to this "different world"** [8].

◦ This distinct technospheric reality necessitates the need for a **"specific ethics of technology"** to address contemporary moral challenges [9].